an Ashokan pillar that is now housed in Allahabad fort. Similarly, Skandagupta, fifth of the Gupta emperors, placed his own inscription in the vicinity of a Mauryan edict in Girnar, Gujarat. In art and literature too we find an echo of the Gupta fascination with the Mauryas. A well known Sanskrit play of this period, *Mudrarakshasa*, is based on the story of how Chanakya and Chandragupta Maurya defeated the Nandas and built their empire.

Many well-known scholars take the view that ancient Indians did not have a sense of history and that the extraordinary continuities of Indian history are somehow accidental or unconscious. It is modern arrogance to think that ancient people were somehow incapable of comprehending their place in history. As we can see, the Gupta monarchs clearly wanted to establish a link not just with the Mauryans but back as far as the Bronze Age. This is why at least two of the Gupta emperors conducted the 'Ashwamedha Yagna' or Vedic Horse Sacrifice—a ritual that was considered ancient even in the fourth century AD. By declaring themselves as Chakravartins, the Guptas were sending the same signal as the Mauryans did through the symbol of the so-called chakra or wheel. At the same time, the Guptas wanted to create a link to the future. The rust-free Iron Pillar in Delhi is usually remembered as an example of advanced metallurgy, but it was not meant as a technological wonder. Its real purpose was to provide a permanent record for posterity. What better way to do this than to inscribe on a solid iron pillar that would never rust?[15]

LIFE IN A GUPTA CITY

Despite the numerous conquests, the Gupta empire was significantly smaller than that of the Mauryas. However, it made up for this in economic and cultural vigour. The two centuries of Gupta rule coincided with the mercantile boom described earlier in this chapter. With ports on both coasts and control over major internal highways, the Gupta economy witnessed a period of exceptional prosperity. This is corroborated by Fa Xian's diaries. Indeed, the country must have been very well governed because, in his